

AI Zoo Website Model

Prototype 3: Functional Prototype

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INFO 691: Prototyping The User Experience

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Product Description

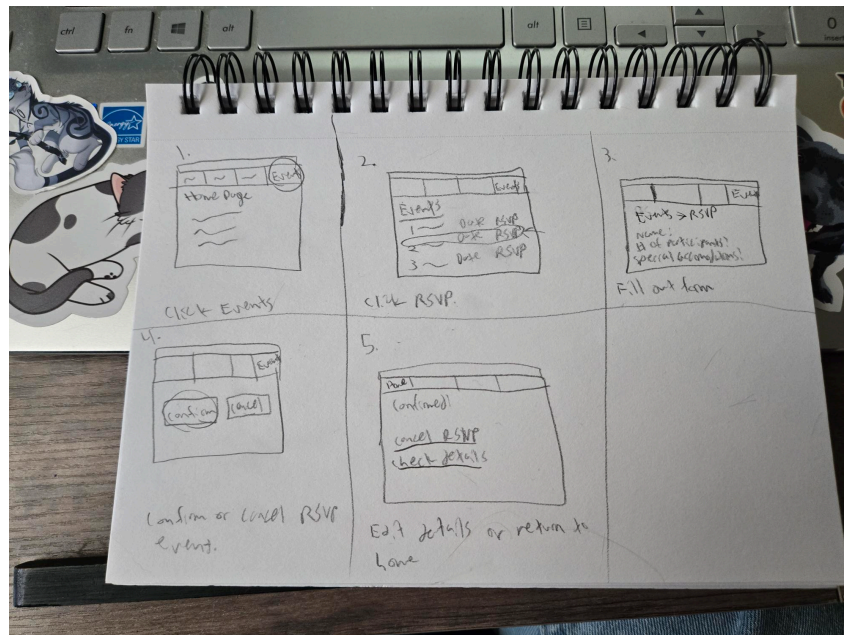
AI Zoo is a futuristic wildlife destination where visitors encounter entirely new species created through the fusion of artificial intelligence and advanced biological engineering. In this zoo of the future, scientists have unlocked the ability to combine and manipulate animal DNA with precision, bringing to life intelligent, hybrid creatures that have never existed before, from neon-scaled feline-avian hybrids to cybernetic aquatic mammals.

The AI Zoo app is designed to enhance and streamline the visitor experience by helping guests browse available exhibits, view upcoming events, and understand associated ticketing and pricing. Whether users are looking to reserve general admission or purchase access to premium experiences, the app provides an intuitive, mobile-friendly interface that makes planning a visit easy and engaging. With detailed information about each AI-generated species and real-time access to zoo offerings, the app empowers visitors to explore the boundaries of nature and technology, all in one place.

Initial Wireframes

To begin designing the AI Zoo experience, our team developed two sets of initial wireframes to map out the core tasks users will complete in the app: RSVPing for special events and purchasing admission tickets.

Wireframe 1: RSVP for Special Events



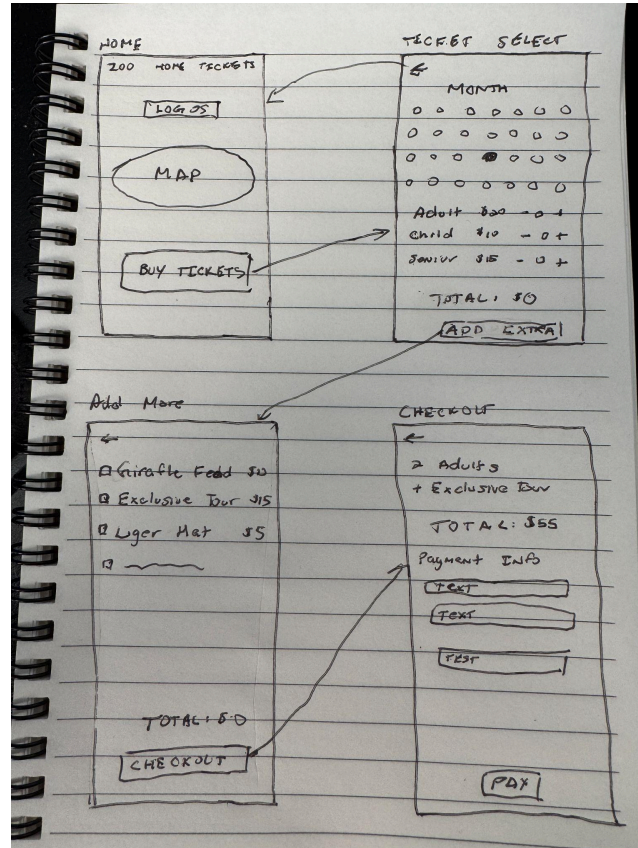
This flow allows users to RSVP to time-sensitive events hosted by the zoo, such as live creature demonstrations or limited-entry AI creature unveilings. The process begins on the homepage, where users can access the events section. From there, they select an event, tap “RSVP,” and fill out a short form. After submitting, users are taken to a confirmation screen where they can either confirm or cancel their RSVP. They also have the option to return and edit their RSVP information.

The wireframe captures the following key interactions:

- Navigating from the homepage to the event list
- Viewing individual event details
- Filling out an RSVP form
- Confirming or editing the RSVP

This process emphasizes clarity and minimal steps, ensuring users can easily secure a spot for high-demand experiences.

Wireframe 2: Purchasing Admission Tickets



This second wireframe focuses on the core functionality of buying general admission tickets. Users begin at the homepage and click "Buy Tickets," leading them to a ticket selection screen where they choose a date from a calendar and select the number of Adult, Child, or Senior tickets. Once selections are made, users can proceed to an "Add Extras" page, where they may include additional experiences such as Giraffe Feeding or the Exclusive Tour. A dynamic total is updated throughout.

The checkout screen summarizes selected tickets and extras and provides a simple payment form. This flow guides users through:

- Date and ticket type selection
- Optional add-ons
- Payment and confirmation

By mapping out these wireframes before starting high-fidelity designs, we were able to identify necessary steps, reduce friction in the user journey, and align the structure and layout of key interactions.

Clickable High-Fidelity Prototype

Our team created a high-fidelity prototype of the AI Zoo app using Figma, which can be explored [here](#). The prototype simulates a simplified version of the AI Zoo website experience, focusing on browsing exhibits and initiating ticket purchases.

Homepage

The homepage features a large, scrollable showcase of AI-generated animals, inviting users to explore the zoo's novel attractions. At the top of the screen is a navigation bar with links to:

- Home
- Exhibits
- Wait Times
- Shop

Users can also find a clear call-to-action to purchase general admission tickets, either directly from the homepage or via the Exhibits section.

Exhibits Page

Clicking on the Exhibits section brings users to a gallery-like experience where they can view additional futuristic animals, each accompanied by names and imagery. This section also includes another call-to-action link that directs users to the ticket purchasing page, encouraging engagement through visual discovery.

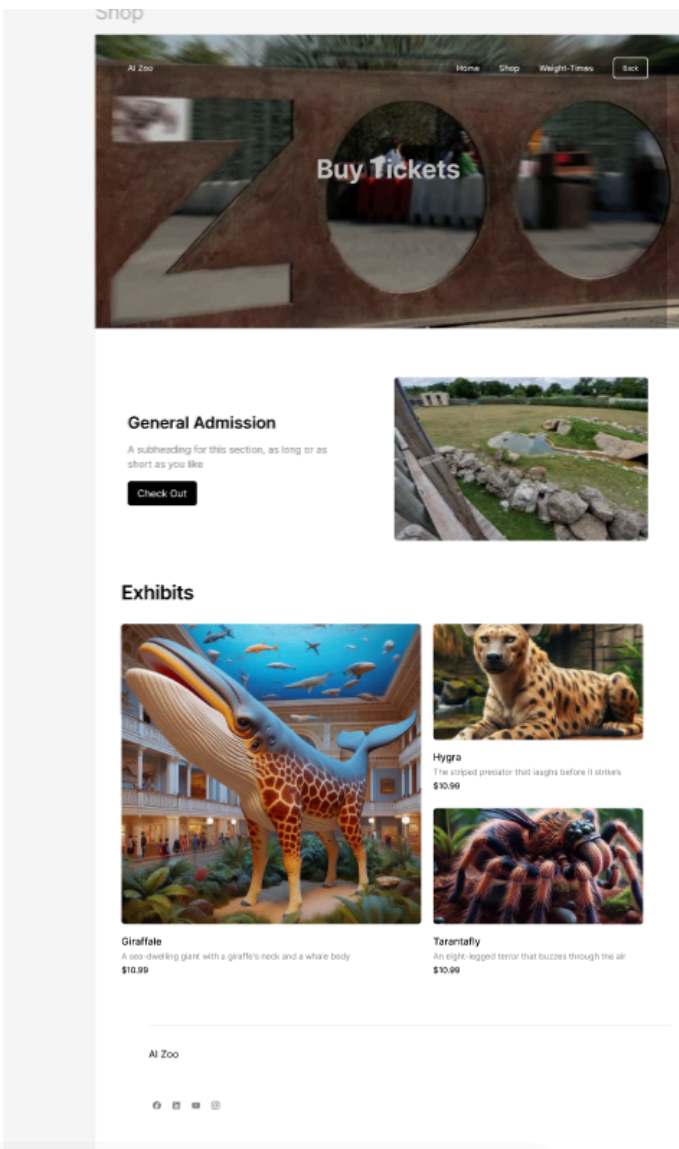
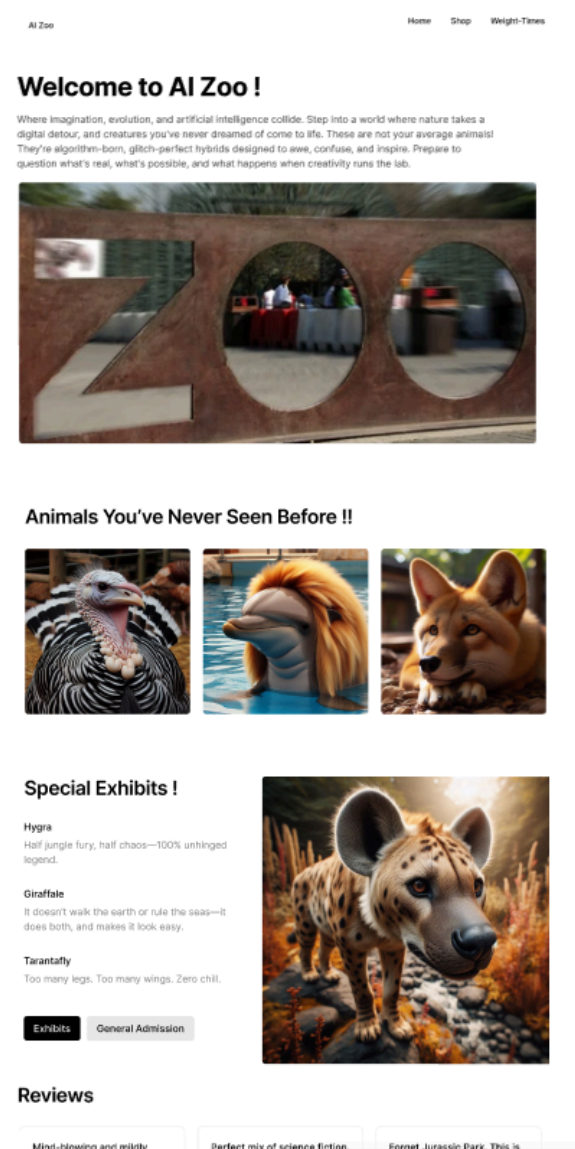
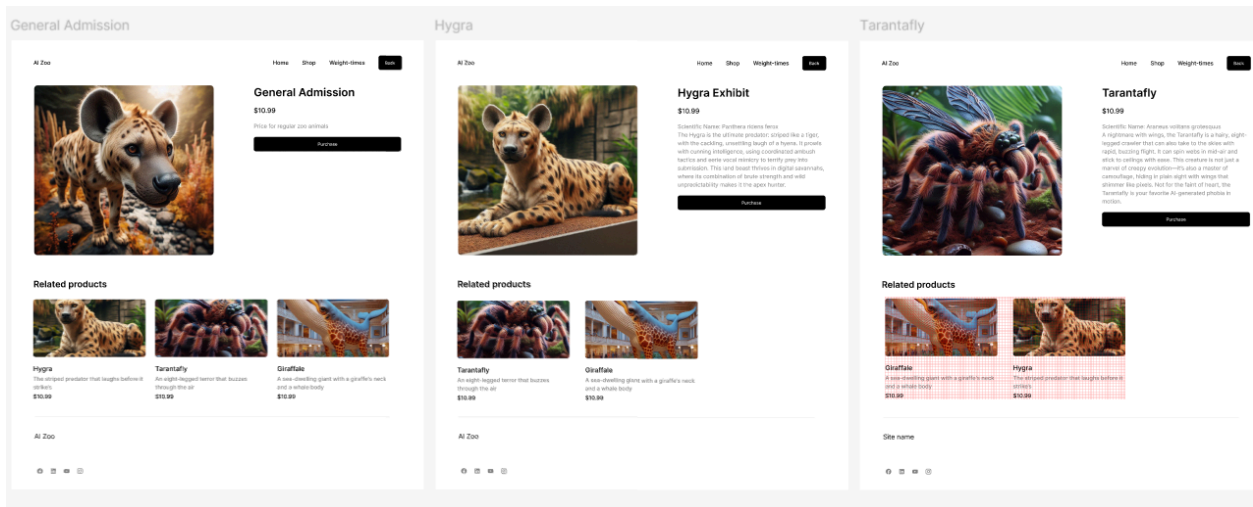
Wait Times

The Wait Times page (accessible from the top nav) is a planning tool where users can preview anticipated crowd levels or peak times for various exhibits. Although the prototype uses placeholder visuals, the page conceptually supports trip planning and user decision-making.

Ticket Access

While the full ticket purchase flow (date selection, quantity, checkout) is not implemented in this prototype, the current version includes clear navigation pathways and interface cues that guide users toward that task. The layout and structure serve as a conceptual foundation for further development of the ticketing experience.

This prototype emphasizes visual storytelling and user engagement through strong imagery and intuitive page flow, reflecting the wonder and novelty of a zoo populated by AI-designed creatures. It also establishes the key touchpoints for exploration and conversion (viewing exhibits → buying tickets).



User Feedback

To evaluate the usability and appeal of the AI Zoo prototype, we conducted informal usability interviews with two potential users representing different demographics. Both participants interacted with the clickable prototype via Figma and provided verbal and written feedback on their experience.

User Profile 1

This user is a 32-year-old UX researcher and a parent of two young children. They are highly comfortable with technology and often plan family outings to attractions like museums, zoos, and theme parks. As a parent, their priorities include efficiency, clarity, and the ability to plan for crowds and ticketing. They appreciated the visual design of the app and the overall ease of navigation but also offered suggestions to make the experience even more family-friendly and intuitive.

Transcript Highlights

Q: What was your first impression of the homepage?

"The animals are stunning, the visuals definitely caught my attention. I love the futuristic theme."

Q: Was it easy to find information about exhibits and tickets?

"Yes, the flow made sense to me. But I think the ticket button could stand out more — maybe with a brighter color or animation?"

Q: Did you try using the Wait Times page?

"Yes, but I wasn't sure how current or accurate the data was supposed to be. A tooltip or explanation would help."

Q: Anything confusing or missing?

"I didn't realize there was a shop until I looked closely at the top bar. Also, once I'm on an exhibit page, it might be helpful to have a quick overview or description of the animal instead of just the image."

User Profile 2

This user is a 24-year-old college student with a strong interest in science fiction and emerging technologies. They frequently explore new digital experiences and are very comfortable using interactive platforms. As a spontaneous solo visitor, they look for quick, visually engaging access to content and appreciate futuristic aesthetics. They responded positively to the app's design and theme but suggested improvements that could make the experience more interactive and immersive.

Transcript Highlights

Q: What did you think of the overall design?

“It looks clean and futuristic. The animal designs are awesome; and very otherworldly. I’d love to see more movement or hover effects though.”

Q: Was navigation straightforward?

“Yeah, it felt intuitive. I liked that there were multiple paths to buying tickets. The wait times page is a cool concept, maybe some filters would make it more interactive?”

Q: What would improve the experience?

“I wanted to click on an animal to learn more. Some sort of modal or detail view would be great. Also, the shop section feels underdeveloped. I think there should be items on the homepage in a section. ”

Summary of Feedback with Action Items

Category	User Likes	User Suggestions	Potential Revisions
Visual Design	Futuristic aesthetic, animal images	Add hover effects, motion	Add microinteractions or subtle animations
Navigation	Easy to move between pages	Ticket CTA needs more visibility	Increase contrast or animate ticket button
Wait Times Page	Concept is useful	Needs explanation of purpose	Add tooltip or short description
Exhibit Pages	Strong visuals	Missing animal descriptions	Add brief bios or facts under each animal
Shop Section	N/A	Easy to miss and feels sparse	Surface a few featured items on homepage or exhibits
Content Exploration	Clear pathways to tickets	Users wanted deeper interaction	Add click-to-expand or modal views for exhibits

Revision Plan

If given another design sprint, our team would focus on:

- Enhancing interactivity with hover states and transitions
- Adding brief descriptions or modals for each animal in the Exhibits section
- Making the Buy Tickets CTA more visually prominent
- Improving the Wait Times page by adding a legend or tooltip
- Expanding the Shop section to feature a few fun, thematic items on the homepage

These revisions would increase engagement and clarity while supporting a more immersive and informative user journey through the AI Zoo.

Design Justifications

The design of the AI Zoo prototype was driven by our goal of creating a futuristic, immersive, and intuitive experience for users visiting a zoo filled with artificially designed creatures. From the beginning, we focused on making the interface both visually appealing and easy to navigate, balancing imaginative storytelling with practical utility.

We started by sketching wireframes for two key flows: purchasing admission tickets and RSVPing for special events. This helped clarify the essential steps for those tasks and how we could guide users through them efficiently. Our wireframes prioritized a clean layout, limited screen transitions per task, and clear call-to-action buttons, decisions that we carried forward into the high-fidelity prototype.

Visually, we designed the homepage to feature large, bold animal images that immediately draw users in and encourage exploration. These visuals serve not only as decorative elements but also as navigational cues, directing visitors to learn more about the futuristic hybrid creatures they can meet in person. This design choice was praised by both users we interviewed, who noted the strong sense of wonder and uniqueness that the visuals created.

To further support engagement and exploration, we included social media links integrated into the homepage and footer. These links direct users to videos, pictures, and event coverage from the AI Zoo's external channels. By adding access to real-time content and community buzz, we aimed to create continuity between the digital preview and the in-person zoo experience, especially for users looking to share or verify what they'll see before visiting.

The overall layout uses a modern, minimalist structure with a clear visual hierarchy, large typography, and ample white space. This ensures that each section feels approachable while still reinforcing the advanced and futuristic theme of the zoo. The site is designed to be accessible and visually clean across devices, emphasizing function while maintaining a sleek, polished aesthetic.

We also implemented a persistent top navigation bar to help users orient themselves, with links to Home, Exhibits, Wait Times, and Shop. However, based on user feedback, we identified areas for improvement, including increasing the visual prominence of the Buy Tickets button and enhancing visibility for the Shop section, which some users initially overlooked.

The Wait Times page was conceptualized as a tool for trip planning, allowing users to check anticipated crowd levels before visiting. Although it remains a basic placeholder in the prototype, it received positive feedback with suggestions for added explanatory context or real-time filtering in future iterations.

In summary, our design intentionally centers user engagement through high-impact visuals, clear pathways to action, and an immersive sci-fi aesthetic. Given more time, we would expand interactive features within the exhibits, enrich animal descriptions, and introduce motion-based elements like hover states or animations to increase user interaction and make the experience even more dynamic.

Reflections

This project pushed us to think beyond merely building an interface; it prompted us to create a believable, engaging user experience for something that doesn't exist yet. Working with the speculative theme of a futuristic zoo filled with AI-designed animals was creatively exhilarating, but it also required us to be especially mindful of clarity and usability. One of the key lessons we learned from this assignment was the significance of grounding a big idea in simple, usable flows.

Our process began with low-fidelity sketches, which turned out to be a highly effective way to get everyone on the same page. Even rough wireframes helped us identify which steps were essential and which could be simplified or merged. This early alignment saved us time later on, especially when we moved into Figma, where it's easy to get caught up in visual polish.

One thing we noticed as we built the high-fidelity prototype was how quickly the scope could expand. Originally, we intended to develop full checkout flows, but we scaled back once we realized how much time would be needed to refine the homepage, exhibits, and navigation. This became an opportunity to practice prioritization: we decided it was better to have a small number of highly focused, well-designed pages than to stretch ourselves too thin.

User feedback was also a humbling part of the process. There were aspects we assumed were intuitive, like where to find the shop or how to interpret the wait times page, that testers either overlooked or misunderstood. Their reactions reminded us that no matter how "cool" a design looks, the experience must communicate clearly. It also reinforced the importance of testing early, even with a minimal prototype.

If we had another sprint, we'd love to explore interaction design in greater depth, especially hover states, modals, and contextual content. We'd also look into how to better guide users through the next steps after they've engaged with an animal or section of the site. Most

importantly, we'd allocate more time for usability testing throughout the design cycle rather than reserving it for the end.

In the end, this project reminded us that prototyping isn't just about building something impressive; it's about storytelling, decision-making, and learning through iteration. We leave this experience not just with a working prototype but with a stronger understanding of how to collaborate, scope, and improve with user insight in mind.